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Imagining “Maritime Asia”

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INTRODUCTION

The question as to what Asia is, and as to whether there existed one or many Asia(s), has been asked many times over the past two decades or so.¹ Yet, in spite of a recent wave of studies foregrounded by “borderless”/ global history, and focusing on intra-Asian connections, today’s mainstream histories and geographies of Asia are largely the result of colonial and post-colonial national narratives, or of post–World War II global academe, which has framed the “Area Studies Paradigm” and (arbitrarily) divided Asia into the quadrants of South, Central, Southeast, and East Asia.

In this chapter I propose to reconceptualize (i.e., reimagine) Asia by widening the geo-historical framework through which the complex mosaic of cultural and religious phenomena linked by a shared deep history are to be investigated. I begin by offering a historiographical survey tracking the history of the concept of “Maritime Asia”, and exploit it to theorize the long-distance maritime connections and dynamics of interaction among societies throughout the swathe of territory stretching from the Indian Ocean littorals to the Western Pacific. I then apply this perspective to the study of the genesis and spread of Sanskritic Buddhism across Maritime Asia from the third to the fourteenth century CE.

¹ Among the most recent contributions are Duara (2010a), Subrahmanyam (2016 and 1997), Acharya (2010), and Milner and Johnson (2001).

THE IDEA OF MARITIME ASIA

Maritime Asia can be conceived as a dynamic macro-region of intersecting discursive fields across which networks of cultural brokers travelled since time immemorial. From the early centuries of the Common Era, this macro-region constituted an integrated system of littorals and hinterlands connected by the sea routes governed by the seasonal monsoon winds. Influenced by similar environmental and climatic factors, Maritime Asia formed an ideal theatre for the circulation of crops, people, goods, languages, beliefs and ritual systems, and ideas.² Spreading across the superimposed geopolitical boundaries of modern nation-states, and transcending such equally arbitrary and historically constructed geographical entities as South/Southeast/East Asia, I imagine Maritime Asia as forming a single interconnected network, and arguably even an integral cultural ecumene with a shared background of human, intellectual, and environmental history. More than a mere (and static) geographical expression, Maritime Asia is a metaphor representing dynamic social networks that may help us to make sense of complex historical processes, like for example the circulation of Indic religions—most notably, tantric traditions—across Asia.³

A recent trend in contemporary scholarship on Asia has been the emphasis on translocal, cosmopolitan phenomena focusing on large-scale processes of socio-cultural and economic integration. Such concepts as Subrahmanyam’s “connected histories”, favouring flexible and fluid cultural zones rather than “civilizational” fixed representations,⁴ have laid the foundations for a new wave of historical scholarship focusing on circulatory processes of cultural transfer. Research produced in the

² Duara (2010b, p. 1028) points out that this circulation was largely peaceful, thereby suggesting a model of Asian connections that is “weakly-bounded, network-oriented, pluralistic, multitemporal”.

³ The choice of not including a map in this chapter is deliberate: a static map, representing a mere geographical container, would not do justice to the dynamic, pulsing, multi-layered, and fluid character of the Maritime Asia model. In the absence of an interactive and dynamic digital model/computer interface, an act of the imagination is required to visualize the fluid and constantly evolving nature of this network, within (but also beyond) its geographical boundaries in the *longue durée*.

⁴ See Subrahmanyam’s (2016, p. 22) critique of the four civilizations existing across the Indian Ocean region, namely “Islam”, “Sanskritic India”, “South East Asia”, and “Chinese”, distinguished by Chaudhuri (1991, pp. 49–66).

past two decades has increasingly relied on the concept of “networks” to elucidate the dynamics of inter-Asian cultural transfer on the one hand, and reoriented the geographical focus towards a maritime/Indian Ocean dimension on the other.

The idea of an interconnected maritime space linking the Indian Ocean to the China Sea appears to have been developed in maritime history circles in France and Germany in the 1990s.⁵ As far as I am aware, the descriptor “Maritime Asia”⁶ has been first used in a systematic way in a series of volumes edited by German Sinologist Roderich Ptak—some of which jointly with French (maritime/Southeast Asia) historians like Denys Lombard and Claude Guillot⁷—on (East) Asian and global maritime history appeared in the late 1990s.⁸ Geoffrey Wade (2003) uses the expression several times in a working paper reviewing European studies on the “Premodern East Asian Maritime Realm”; depending on the context, it appears to be synonymous with “maritime East Asia”, “maritime Southeast Asia”, or to denote the maritime space between Japan, Taiwan, and Southeast Asia, or again represent a neutral (and vague) expression akin to “maritime Europe” (denoting Europe’s “maritime space”).⁹ Along similar lines,

⁵ The preface to the volume *From the Mediterranean to the China Sea: Miscellaneous Notes*, edited by Claude Guillot, Denys Lombard, and Roderich Ptak (1998), mentions a second “Franco-German initiative on Maritime Asian History”, which culminated in a symposium held in Paris in 1997.

⁶ The expression is often printed as “maritime Asia” (with the “m” of “maritime” in lower case), but occasionally, “Maritime Asia” is also used, such as in the Preface to Guillot, Lombard and Ptak (1998).

⁷ Ptak is apparently “inspired by the work of Denys Lombard on Southeast Asian concepts of maritime space, which in turn was inspired by Fernand Braudel’s famous work on the Mediterranean” (Willis 2005).

⁸ Cf. the Series *South China and Maritime Asia*, edited by Ptak, which includes, among other publications, *Asia Maritima: Images et réalité 1200–1800* (Lombard and Ptak 1994), and the above-mentioned volume by Guillot, Lombard, and Ptak (1998). See also the edited volume *Maritime Asia: Profit Maximisation, Ethics and Trade Structure* (Sprengard and Ptak 1994). In a more recent monograph, Ptak (2007) uses the term “*Die Maritime Seidenstraße*”. The legacy of this intellectual tradition has been furthered in recent studies by Angela Schottenhammer (see Schottenhammer 2007; Antony and Schottenhammer 2017).

⁹ This appears to be the case in a number of contributions in the field of East Asian Studies and International Studies, where “maritime Asia” would seem to reflect a Sino-centric bias: see, e.g., Leonard (1972), Brook (2017), and Busch (2013).

Robert Antony (2017) uses the descriptors “East–Southeast Asian Maritime”, “Maritime Silk Road”, “South China Sea World” and “Maritime Eastern Asia” as applying primarily to “the whole of Eastern Asia—from Korea and Japan in the north to Sumatra and the Celebes Islands in the south”, and forming “a huge intra-regional system... an immense area [that] transcended political, linguistic, ethnic, and cultural boundaries” (ibid., p. 11).

While the denominator Maritime Asia remains relatively marginal in the panorama of Area Studies and global knowledge, which prediliges the expression “Maritime Silk Roads”¹⁰ to denote a supra-national, sea-focused conceptualization of Indian Ocean–China Sea connectivity, it seems to have become popular in the jargon of recent publications in the fields of Strategic and International Studies, especially from China and Japan.¹¹ As such, it has fared much less well than the—in several respects cognate—term “Eurasia”, which is now commonly used in mainstream historical scholarship, Area Studies, International Relations and, indeed, public discourse. Both terms Eurasia and Maritime Asia have contingent origins, and have not been used in a consistent way by scholars; yet, according to Hann (2016, p. 2), Eurasia “remains the best term available to denote the largest landmass of the planet, including large islands such as Great Britain and Japan”. In the same way, Maritime Asia (or Oceanic Asia) may be one of the best terms to describe the southeastern rim of Asia, or the swathe of maritime and mainland territory from the Indian Subcontinent to Japan.¹² As the word Eurasia was coined to correct an ancient bias implying and separation between Europe and Asia (ibid., p. 1), so Maritime Asia seems to have been coined to correct the bias of

¹⁰ The conceptualization of “Silk Roads of the sea” might go back to French scholar Chavannes (1903, p. 233). Sen (2014a, p. 39) argues that the labels (Maritime/Overland) “Silk Road(s)/Route(s)” are misnomers, for “Silk from China was neither the earliest nor the most commonly traded commodity. The early history of maritime trade indicates the prevalence of beads, precious stones, and pearls as the main merchandise; during the later periods, bulk goods, such as incense, pepper, spices, and porcelain dominated the trading activity” (cf. Whitfield 2007, pp. 208–10; Antony 2017, p. 1). However, since the terms “Silk Road(s)/Route(s)” have become part of the modern global parlance, I will not refrain from using them here.

¹¹ Wade (2003) refers to a symposium held on the occasion of the 10th Anniversary of the Japanese Research Group of Maritime Asian History, “The Potential of Maritime Asian History”, Naha, Okinawa, Japan, on 1 November 2003.

¹² The other being “Monsoon Asia”: see below.

landmass-based history, as well as arbitrary boundaries set by Area Studies and metageography.

Ptak and other (maritime) historians have refrained from embarking on a precise definition of Maritime Asia, considering it as a chain of spaces and exchanges rather than a continuum or unity; indeed, to my knowledge, the expression has never been defined and contextualized so as to represent a coherent heuristic device to reframe our current conceptualizations of Asia as a region.¹³ An attempt to move towards that direction is Barbara Andaya's short study "Oceans Unbounded: Transversing Asia across 'Area Studies'" (2007).¹⁴ Capitalizing on the recent endorsements on the centrality of maritime history, Andaya attempts to "transverse the academic divides separating the study of 'South', 'East' and 'Southeast' Asia", and widen the discourse to global history by using the expression "maritime Asia". It is worth quoting some key paragraphs here:

... envisaging an interconnected maritime Asia¹⁵ that is not subservient to the boundaries of area studies and modern nations, and yet does not descent to the simplistic and overly general, is a formidable challenge. A number of studies have tracked trading diasporas and economic linkages, but the place of the oceans in the cultures of Asia's littoral societies has received much less attention. (ibid., p. 1)

It is the human dimension that makes this interlocking relationship between land and ocean such a compelling teaching device. If we insist

¹³ Duara occasionally mentions the expression in his work, yet without giving a clear definition of it (cf., e.g., 2010b, pp. 1027–28, where, having referred to Jack Goody's persuasive argument about the interconnectedness of the Eurasian world, moves on to describe maritime Asia as a model of de-militarized Asian connectivity). Similarly, Willis (1993) does not define its usage (and, like Duara and others, avoids the use of the capital "M" in "maritime"). Antony (2017) uses the descriptor "Maritime Asia" in the title of Chapter I of the edited volume *Beyond the Silk Roads* ("Integrating Maritime Asia with World, Transregional, and Local History: An Introduction"); however, while making a strong case for the need of a paradigm-shift that disentangles Asian maritime history from Eurocentric or Sinocentric models, he nowhere employs, let alone define, the expression "Maritime Asia" in the chapter itself.

¹⁴ The version printed in the *Asia-Pacific Journal/Japan Focus* is a modified version of the one published in the *Journal of Asian Studies* 65/4, November 2006, pp. 669–90. Both reproduce her presidential address to the annual meeting of the Association for Asian Studies (AAS) in San Francisco, 6 April 2006.

¹⁵ The 2006 version of the study reads: "interconnected Asia". The expression "maritime Asia" occurs, however, on p. 674.

that the sea and those who live with the sea deserve a more prominent place in our study of Asia, we will take an important step in developing the framework required for any comparative overview. In turn, this framework will go a long way towards overcoming the confines of so-called area-studies while redressing the scholarly preoccupation with land-based societies that has so informed the presentation of Asian cultures. (ibid., p. 3)

The “transocean” standpoint may enable us not merely to work with a larger canvas, but to capture something of the human encounters that underwrite the communication between areas and between peoples. Although there is probably no way we can be what Rhoads Murphey once termed a “complete Asianist” (Murphey 1988), we can do our best to think across the boundaries of disciplines, areas and a presentism that privileges the land. As we work ever harder to bring Asia into the academic mainstream, an understanding of the ocean and of how it shaped the lives of real people may open up new perspectives on the intertwined histories that should be integral to our projection of “Asia”. (ibid., p. 18)

As challenging as it may be to arrive at a definition that is not overly general and simplistic, I conceptualize Maritime Asia as the largely maritime geographical expanse, encompassing Monsoon Asia¹⁶ and the Indomalaya Ecozone,¹⁷ spanning the eastern littorals of the Indian Subcontinent (and their hinterlands) in the west¹⁸ to the South China Sea littorals (and their hinterlands), the Philippine islands, Taiwan, Korea, the Ryukyus and Japan in the northeast. The fulcrums of this region are the littorals of peninsular and mainland Southeast Asia, and the Malay-Indonesian Archipelago. Borrowing the metaphors of “cores” and “edges” applied by Wang Gungwu (see Ooi 2015, p. 121) to describe the system formed by the Eurasian

¹⁶ A historiographical appraisal of this idea, coined by Jules Sion in the 1920s and further developed by Paul Mus in the 1930s, is Acri forthcoming.

¹⁷ See Figure 10.1 in Sinclair, this volume.

¹⁸ In fact, the westernmost limits could perhaps be extended to the island of Socotra between the Indian Ocean and the Red Sea/Eastern Africa (see Sinclair, this volume, p. 291). As pointed out by Subrahmaniam (2016, p. 19), for the Portuguese “there seems to have been no great desire to distinguish maritime Asia from East Africa, which for them formed a part of the same navigational continuum, and was also comprehended under the same administrative title of the *Estado da Índia*”.

continent on the one hand and the Mediterranean Sea and North Africa on the other, I regard the Western Asian littorals on the Indian Ocean, the Persian Gulf and Red Sea, the Eastern African littorals, inner continental (North) India and China, Korea and Japan, the Western Pacific (i.e. Papua New Guinea and Melanesia), and even the Australian northern shores as “appendices” or “edges” linked to the sea- and land-based networks of economic, cultural, and religious exchange that collectively shaped Maritime Asia. It is worth mentioning here Lieberman’s (2009, p. 10) conceptualization of premodern Eurasia as part of a coherent, integrated *Ecumene* connected to Southeast and East Asian “appendices” that, through comparative study, reveals parallel but independent social adaptations, climatic shifts, and commercial links—what he calls “strange parallels”, i.e., synchronous developments between geographically distant regions in Southeast Asia and the wider Eurasian area. Paraphrasing and coalescing Lieberman’s (2009, p. 10) set of questions on premodern Eurasia, I ask: in what ways and to what extent can we regard (the cores of) premodern Maritime Asia as a coherent *ecumene*?

Maritime Asia may be conceptualized not only as a world region, but also as a “socio-spatial grouping” (Lewis and Wigen 1997) constituted by a pattern of ever-changing relations dominated by basic underlying affinities.¹⁹ This region comprised a web of coastal and inland polities connected to each other through a network of cosmopolitan port-cities across the Bay of Bengal/Indian Ocean and the South China Sea/Western Pacific Ocean, forming a “single ocean” (Wolters 1999, pp. 44–45) or, rather, a “Two-Ocean Mediterranean” (Wang Gungwu in Ooi 2015, pp. 57–93). Following an increasing recognition of the predominant role played by the sea routes or Maritime Silk Roads in shaping premodern intra-Asian connectivity, it seems appropriate to study cosmopolitan cultural phenomena as participating in complex circulatory processes involving economic/mercantile, diplomatic, and religious networks moving across the maritime and littoral expanse encircling the southern rim of Asia. The emphasis on the maritime routes—which were fundamentally interlinked with overland routes (see Whitfield 2007, pp. 206–8)—reflects the need to reposition them as keys in shaping intra-Asian connectivity. For instance,

¹⁹ For Lewis and Wigen (1997, pp. 186–88), “world regions” cannot be defined on the basis of the idea of political and ecological boundaries, but on the basis of historical processes that yield an “assemblage of ideas, practices, and social institutions”.

Ray (2013, p. 13) rightly notes that “though the seas have been important for the five millennia of human history, they are also the most glossed over in historical discourse, which has tended to focus on predominantly land-based national histories”. Indeed, we need to realize that the Indian Ocean was not a physical and intellectual barrier between South and Southeast Asia, but rather a space favouring exchange and interaction. Already in 1933, Mus described the sea as a unifying factor in the region of Monsoon Asia:

The wide distribution over the surface of the globe of the regions I have just mentioned is not as absolute a barrier as you might be tempted to believe at first. For too long, ethnography has proceeded by purely continental groupings.... A hundred, two hundred or a thousand kilometres of sea, especially where there are prevailing winds, are a distance much less considerable than a hundred, two hundred or a thousand kilometres of land, divided by mountains, forests and hostile tribes ... whenever sea lanes establish communication, it is reasonable to expect a cultural unity.... (Mus 1975, p. 9 [1933]).

Here I also think about Pearson’s insight that the societies inhabiting the Indian Ocean littorals might have “more in common with other littoral societies than they do with their inland neighbours” (2006, p. 353). Cutting across the natural boundaries and barriers of continental topography, sea-based routes formed a network of conduits that led to the formation of translocal cultural phenomena such as the “Sanskrit Cosmopolis” (Pollock 2006) and the “Pali Cosmopolis” (Frasch 2017). Several scholars have highlighted the interconnected and cosmopolitan nature of the premodern Indian Ocean trade network. According to Kauz (2010, p. 1), this network emerged as a “largely coherent structure, and has been a space which served as a huge stratum connecting the various kingdoms and cultures adjacent to it, causing interchanges in all possible fields and certainly mutual influences”. Asking whether the history of the civilizations around and beyond the Indian Ocean exhibit any intrinsic and perceptible unity, expressed in terms of space, time, or structures, Chaudhuri has found “a basic underlying structure, the ground floor of material life, which remained invariant while displaying variations within certain limits” (1993, pp. 1, 7). According to him (1985, p. 23), the unifying factor that “brought the whole [Indian Ocean rim] area within the operation of a single local variable” was the cyclical monsoon wind. By following the rhythms of the monsoons, sailors were forced to wait for months in foreign ports for the

contrary winds that would take them back home, thus becoming agents and recipients of cultural transactions.

The physical and human unit that Chaudhury calls the “Indian Ocean system” was not limited to the sea, but included the hinterlands—even when they are far away from the shores—as its integral part (1985).²⁰ Similarly, Pearson (2003) has stressed the “deep structure” underlying the Indian Ocean, including climatic and physical factors. Andre G. Frank (1998) has considered the Indian Ocean area as extending to the South China Sea, and as having been central in global history for at least five millennia up to about 1800. Even more importantly, Andaya (2007, p. 6) has argued against treating the Ocean as a mere “transport surface”, or a neutral medium by which goods and people moved from a place to another. Highlighting the need to imagine “the human reality that initiated and sustained commercial exchanges along ocean pathways”, she views the sea “as a space for creative human activity”. A scholarly desideratum is, therefore, to evaluate the impact of the sea in shaping a “maritime imaginary”. As a matter of fact, most of Southeast Asia’s population lives in coastal areas, and is thus subjected to a high degree of marine influence on social mores and material and immaterial culture (*ibid.*, pp. 9–12). Linguistics and archaeology have confirmed this situation: witness the boat-shaped coffins found throughout Maritime Asia (often even at a remove from the coasts), the synonymy of the words “boat” and “coffin”, the “boat-shaped” roofs of house architecture, and terms to denote social and political elements calqued on navigational jargon. Across the vast Indo-Pacific zone, boats and navigation techniques were not only connected to material technology, but also to bodies of knowledge about geography, astronomy, atmospheric phenomena, tidal and current patterns, fauna, etc. It would be unreasonable not to assume that some of those bodies of knowledge did not interact with—in the sense of both influencing and being influenced by—the beliefs, mythologies, and rituals that contributed

²⁰ This aspect is also stressed on Project Mausam’s (see below, p. 53) official website: “The central themes that hold Project ‘Mausam’ together are those of cultural routes and maritime landscapes that not only linked different parts of the Indian Ocean littoral, but also connected the coastal centres to their hinterlands” (<http://ignca.gov.in/project-mausam-3/project-mausam>, accessed 29 June 2019). The aspect of Indian Ocean-hinterland connectivity is effectively highlighted in the edited volume on the Northern Bay of Bengal before colonialism by Mukherjee (2011).

to shape the cultures of the communities living in the maritime space that covers about a half of the earth’s surface. Furthermore, it is becoming increasingly clear that communities living in coastal regions (and their connected hinterlands) experienced cosmopolitan dynamics, which can be contrasted to the more conservative and isolated communities living on mountains—some sort of “uplands-lowlands” dichotomy or “vertical geography” that has been invoked, for example, to make a case for the existence of the area of Zomia (Perdue 2013, p. 379).

Keeping in mind the above, it seems to be high time to revisit the deep past of Maritime Asia from the perspective of geoenvironmental history and maritime connectivity, and advocate a new approach that will explore the correlations between the physical environment and the multidirectional dispersal of people, goods and ideas. More evidence of prehistoric contacts between South Asia, Southeast Asia, and East Asia has turned up in recent years. The presence of jar burials, Dongson drums, Sa-Huynh ornaments, and agate and carnelian beads along the Indo-Pacific arc (Theunissen, Grave and Bailey 2000; Calò 2014) suggests the possibility of interactions and transfer of religious ideas and practices from East to South Asia, while studies on the distribution of ceramics, cowries, cultigens, and nautical terms and devices, have highlighted the regular maritime links between early farming communities in South, Southeast Asia, and East Asia since at least the first millennium BCE (Gupta 2005, p. 22; Hoogervorst 2013, p. 102; Selvakumar 2011; Yang 2014). In a series of recent studies, Bellina (2014, 2018) and Favereau and Bellina (2016) discuss Maritime Southeast Asian populations’ socio-political and economic developments when the region became part of the Maritime Silk Roads system, highlighting long distance interactions and processes of globalization cross the South China Sea–Indian Ocean networks in the late prehistoric and early historical period. Building on archaeological evidence and biological and linguistic reconstructions (Bellwood 2011), as well as such ideas as Solheim’s (2006) “Nusantao” linguistic and cultural network in the South China Sea,²¹ Bellina (2018) presents new data on technology and material culture that suggests the existence of a prehistoric Maritime Southeast Asian “cultural matrix” prior to and during the region’s integration into the wider trans-Asiatic

²¹ According to Solheim, the Nusantao Maritime Trading Network covered the vast region from Japan to Madagascar and was established in 5000 BC.

maritime networks. A religious matrix extending over Monsoon Asia in the pre- and early historical period has been theorized by Dentan (2002, 2017), and discussed further by Acri (2017).

Gupta (2005, p. 21) distinguishes interactive, long-distance “processes of human dispersals and techno-cultural diffusions (including the Neolithic expansion from southern China into Southeast Asia) and short-term movements of men and material inspired by trade opportunities”, arguing that the latter were usually effected through conduits opened by earlier expansions. As noted by Hoogervorst (2013, p. 12) along similar lines, there is an increasing awareness that “literary references to commercial activities between these state-level societies [across the Indian Ocean] only reveal the culmination of much older networks”, which in the case of South and Southeast Asia go back to at least the second half of the second millennium BCE—thus well before the beginning of the phenomenon of “Indianization”. Nephrite artefacts from Southeast Asia and Taiwan, dating to between 3000 BCE and 500 CE, have been unearthed through much of mainland Southeast Asia and the Philippines, thus providing evidence for extensive sea-based trade networks across the South China Sea (Hung et al. 2007). Long-range contacts between North China and the South China Sea or even the Indian Ocean are suggested by the findings of shell cowries in elite burials of Northern China as early as the second millennium BCE (Li 2003; Liu 2004). Certain “Austronesian” cultural and religious features have been detected in premodern Japan (Abalahin 2011, pp. 661, 676), while an argument (still preliminary, and controversial) in favour of an early direct influence from pre-Indicized Southeast Asia (and Java in particular) to Japan has been made by some scholars (Kumar 2009; Kumar and Rose 2000; Toichi, 1974; Waterson 1990, pp. 15–17).²² Cameron (2017, pp. 25–26) has produced new archaeological evidence on the existence of a “Prehistoric Maritime Silk Road” constituting “one of a series of interaction spheres that dovetailed into other interaction spheres in the Indian Ocean extending all the way to the Indian subcontinent” from ca. 3000 BCE onwards. Blench (2013) has hypothesized an “arc of

²² The existence of these trade and cultural networks is supported by environmental factors, namely, the currents linking Southern Japan and the Ryukyus islands to Taiwan and the Philippines (Andaya 2007, p. 6). Strikingly enough, the chant of a priestess in a royal Ryukyu anthology of 1531 “summons the spirits of Japan, China, Java and ‘the southern seas’” (ibid.).

vegeculture” as early as 10,000 BP, characterized by tubers, Musaceae, sago exploitation and sugar-cane stretching between Melanesia and Eastern Nepal, correlated with linguistic evidence as well as a suite of material culture items and, perhaps, ideas. Significant instances of global (maritime) interconnections—especially in the realm of material culture—in the ancient world have been invoked by Holmes and Standen (2018, pp. 10–11) to make a point about the heuristic validity of the category “Global Middle Ages”: for instance, the corals from Southeast Asia used in a ca. eleventh-century Buddhist reliquary from northeastern China, the visits of seafarers from Sulawesi to the islands or northern coast of the Australian land mass, Chinese pottery found in archaeological contexts in the Middle East, Africa, Southeast Asia and Australia, etc. It is a current desideratum for historians to connect all these findings, interpret them in the light of an overarching model, and integrate them into a new narrative, for which the category of Maritime Asia could provide a coherent geographical and socio-spatial framework.²³

IMAGINING SANSKRITIC BUDDHISM(S) IN MEDIAEVAL MARITIME ASIA

Buddhism was an important unifying factor in Asian history. It partook of, and had an impact on, the imaginaries and related practices characterizing the Sanskritic continuum that shaped many regional sociocultural contexts in Maritime Asia, thus becoming a phenomenon of enormous importance for global history of ideas.²⁴

The spread of Buddhism, and especially of its Sanskritic varieties, across Asia has been mainly studied from a perspective focusing on transmission through the overland routes or “Silk Roads”, and emphasizing Central Asia as an important transit corridor and contact zone between South and East Asia. However, recent scholarship has recognized the contribution of the southern rim of Asia—especially South India, Sri Lanka, and Southeast Asia—to the genesis, transformation, and circulation

²³ An edited volume surveying evidence of pre- and proto-historical maritime cultural transfer within the geoenvironmental area of Monsoon Asia is Aciri, Blench and Landmann 2017.

²⁴ See Sinclair’s chapter on Sanskritic Buddhism in this volume.

of various forms of Buddhism(s).²⁵ Applying the perspective of Maritime History, Indian Ocean Studies, and Global History to Buddhist Studies, and advocating the necessity to uphold a “geographically wide framing of almost every question that can be asked about Esoteric Buddhism” (Kim and Linrothe 2014, p. 2), a strong argument can be made for the important and constitutive role played by the sea and the Southern Asian littoral and insular regions in the genesis and circulation of Buddhism across the socio-spatial grouping of Maritime Asia from the third to the fourteenth century and beyond (Acri 2016, 2018).²⁶ This geographically wide, and chronologically extended, perspective emphasizes the maritime interactions that occurred across geographical and cultural boundaries in the region comprised a web of coastal and inland polities connected to each other through a network of cosmopolitan ports and entrepôts from the Bay of Bengal to the South and East China Seas. In so doing, it advances an alternative, and complementary, historical narrative that takes the “southern pathways”, i.e., the sea-based networks, into due consideration, thereby revealing the limits of a historiography that is uniquely premised on land-based, “northern pathways” of transmission of Buddhism(s) across the Eurasian landmass. This transregional approach emphasizes the mobile networks of human agents, textual corpora, and visual/architectural models and icons, and also contextualizes the religious, historical, and socio-political dynamics—intervening on a local/regional as well as cosmopolitan/supralocal scale—that shaped these networks as

²⁵ A critique against the predominant land-based approach in the spread of Buddhism across Asia has been advanced by Sen (2014a, p. 40). In an earlier work, Sen (2003) has unveiled the multidirectional connections existing between Asian Buddhist centres in the seventh century and their integration in the wider Asian Buddhist world in the eighth century, characterized by overlapping networks of relations that were religious as much as economic, diplomatic, and political in nature.

²⁶ The primary chronological framework of my studies is the period that I define by way of convention as “mediaeval”, i.e., the widely used periodization referring to the post-Gupta period of South Asian history (especially as per Davidson 2002; cf. 2015, pp. 372–73). I extend the application of mediaeval to the wider area of Maritime Asia, as done by Sprengard and Ptak (2004, p. vii), and also by Wong and Heldt (2014, p. 16) with respect to China, “as a gesture to a more global history” (ibid.)—compare Abu-Lughod’s (1989) and Pollock’s (2006) application of the term to the Eurasian world, as well as the recent, ground-breaking and promising contribution towards the conceptualization of the “Global Middle Ages” with a focus on dynamic connections and social interactions by Holmes and Standen 2018 (and several articles in the same special issue of the journal *Past & Present*).

they moved across different geographical and cultural worlds, in order to achieve a coherent and unitary narrative to account for this complex phenomenon of translocal cultural transfer.

Although Chinese records documenting long-distance transfer of Buddhism from its northeastern Indian cradle to the outlying regions of South India, Sri Lanka, Southeast Asia, and China via the maritime routes date back to the early centuries of the Current Era, it is from the fifth century onwards that written and material evidence becomes increasingly substantial, testifying to an efflorescence of long-distance maritime contacts that were to last for several centuries to come.²⁷ A significant number of Buddhist monks of different ethnicities travelled far and wide, moving along the maritime routes connecting South, East, and Southeast Asia. Those sea routes, established over the centuries by a steady flow of traders and seafarers, were also plied by pilgrims and religious specialists who crossed oceans and lands in search of knowledge, Sanskrit scriptures, relics, icons, and political sponsors.

As is shown by textual, epigraphic, and art historical materials—including icons, ritual accoutrements, *dhāraṇīs*, manuscripts, and monuments—Buddhist cults, imaginaries, and ritual technologies flourished across the vast swathe of littoral, island, and hinterland territory of Maritime Asia. Buddhist vestiges recovered from the Indian Subcontinent littorals, Sri Lanka, the Maldives Islands, peninsular and coastal mainland Southeast Asia, and what are now called the Indonesian Archipelago and the Philippine islands, speak in favour of the existence of pervasive and sustained multidirectional Buddhist exchanges among interconnected nodes linking South Asia and the Western Indian Ocean to China, Korea and Japan through the maritime routes. A polycentric,²⁸ geographically wide, and maritime-based approach is, therefore, an intellectual *sine qua non* to fully appreciate how religious, mercantile, and diplomatic networks acted as catalysts for transmission of Buddhism far and wide across Asia over more

²⁷ Of course, the Hindu and Buddhist networks took over earlier, pre- and early historical networks initiated by Austronesian- and Austroasiatic-speaking navigators (Sen 2014a, p. 40; 2014b, pp. 35–36).

²⁸ A strong case for a multicentric circulation of Buddhism rather than a monodirectional transmission from a South Asian “homeland” to Southeast and East Asian “peripheries” has been made by Sen (2003), while Neelis (2011) has advanced a “networks approach” or “networks model” to study early Buddhism and trade networks in northwestern India. This approach individuates the nodes, conduits, and hubs that facilitated the dynamic processes of exchange, thus going beyond the metaphors of cultural “influences” that have so far characterized the scholarly discourse.

than a millennium. This approach could rectify misconceptions such as the received idea that the southern regions of India and maritime Southeast Asia had a marginal role in the Buddhist Cosmopolis, combined with an overemphasis on the dominance of Theravāda/Pali Buddhism in Sri Lanka and mainland Southeast Asia. Prior to the thirteenth century, both Sri Lanka and Southeast Asia hosted important (and even predominant, in the case of the latter area) Sanskritic Buddhist traditions, and played a constitutive role in the genesis and transmission of both nascent and consolidated forms of Mahāyāna and Mantranaya Buddhism across Maritime Asia from the fifth to the thirteenth century. Rather than constituting mere stopovers and entrepôts for traders and voyagers, the two regions were frequented by monks and laymen alike to collect texts, relics, and icons, visit pilgrimage sites, acquire knowledge in institutionalized centres of higher learning or renowned individual masters, and receive patronage. The Malay Peninsula, Sumatra, and Java formed a strategic geographical area in the Maritime Silk Roads system that has yielded significant vestiges of its glorious Hindu and Buddhist past, yet is still under-represented in contemporary scholarship. Far from being a cultural backwater that passively received Indic influences, it held an integral place in the Buddhist world as both a crossroads and terminus of contacts since the early centuries of the Common Era. At any rate, while the contribution of the Austronesian-speaking region of Nusantara to the Indian Ocean trade network has been recognized in terms of providing superior shipping technology, nautical terminology, and ship crews, the creative and constitutive force of Southeast Asian agents and milieux in the transfer, transformation, and translocation of people, texts, notions, and artefacts in the Buddhist world remains to be fully appreciated. Indeed, a number of monks who travelled the sea routes and visited Southeast Asia—such as, e.g., Guṇavarman, Paramārtha, Yijing, Vajrabuddhi, Amoghavajra, and Atiśa—stirred up new developments in China as well as Tibet and the Indian Subcontinent.

While it is undeniable that the overland and maritime Silk Roads were fundamentally interlinked and complementary (Whitfield 2007), the combined archaeological and textual evidence points to a predominant role of the latter in enabling the mobility of Buddhist agents, artefacts, texts, and ideas over long distances from the early centuries of the first millennium CE. Maritime travel was the faster, most economical, and safest way to move people and goods in the ancient world. The sea was a connecting factor in Asian history since time immemorial, and around the first centuries CE, the seasonal Monsoon winds were exploited by maritime traders plying the routes connecting the ports in the Mediterranean Sea

with those along the coastal and insular areas of South, Southeast, and East Asia. By the middle of the seventh century CE, factors such as a radical expansion of commercial maritime routes connecting South with East Asia, as well as the gradual decline of Buddhism and Buddhist exchanges in Central Asia following the Muslim conquest of Transoxiana and other socio-political contingencies, contributed significantly to the sea-based exchange not only of mercantile goods but also of Buddhist beliefs and ritual practices, and ultimately led to the formation of a global Buddhist Asia. Unlike the Central Asian ones, the interlocking maritime networks of Buddhism survived well past the thirteenth century into the nineteenth century, for instance the Bay of Bengal circuit linking Sri Lanka to Myanmar and Thailand, and the China Sea circuit linking China to Southeast Asia, Korea, and Japan (Sen 2014a, p. 55; 2014b, pp. 33–34).

CONCLUSION

Adhering to the intellectual agenda of the volume, and following the lead of recent scholarship revealing the arbitrariness of the Area Studies divide, in this chapter I have encouraged an “oceanic turn”, a *longue durée* approach, and a widening of the geo-historical framework to the study of the translocal dynamics that govern historical processes transcending the boundaries of both nation-states and macro-regions as they are commonly framed in the current academe. I have also questioned the idea of Asia as a geographical continent constituted by clearly defined discrete “regions”, and conceptualized it as a fluid space characterized by socio-cultural dynamics and environmental factors spanning across discrete histories and geographies.

In advocating the need for a unified historiography of the supralocal system of Maritime Asia, I should like to stress that I do not regard that concept as a “container” (i.e., a mere geographical expression), but rather as dynamic pattern, or “matrix”, of linguistic, cultural, and material interactions and processes of adoption and rejection (or “homogenization” and “heterogenization”) intervened over a vast—yet interconnected—area influenced by similar geo-environmental factors. In revisiting the theoretical framing of the idea of Maritime Asia by previous scholarship and reinterpreting it as a continuum—analogue to the “Indian Ocean world” or “Eurasia”—that could help us to make sense of complex interconnected phenomena in the *longue durée*, I have followed Subrahmanyam’s concept of “connected histories” that favours flexible and fluid cultural zones rather than “civilizational” fixed representations, and also critiqued too a

narrow-focused micro-history, “localized” ethnography and philology, and Area Studies compartmentalization.

It seems to me that the (not entirely unmotivated) negative perception towards the elaboration of grand narratives that has characterized academe from the last decade of the twentieth century, which has elevated “teleology and anachronism to the status of cardinal sins” and sometimes shown “an aversion towards asking basic questions about how we got where we are today” (Strathern 2018, p. 318), is now being problematized by a new trend of connective scholarship seeing comparative coherence to periods applied to a global perspective (for instance, the “Medieval” and the “Early Modern”). As summarized by Strathern (2018, p. 325) when discussing “Global Early Modernity”, “if the diverse societies of the world are becoming more interconnected it makes sense that they will come to exhibit other comparable developments to the extent that there is some kind of loose holistic logic to their emergence”. Inscribing my intellectual project in this perspective emphasizing comparativism and connectivity in the framework of temporal periodizations and spatial (re)configurations, I regard the metaphor of Maritime Asia as a powerful heuristic tool to capture the dynamics across space and time that connects seemingly disconnected phenomena, actors, geographies, and historical trajectories, to form a coherent narrative. This narrative may not be limited to definite “periods”: for instance, it may be argued that the “new” Hindu and Buddhist networks of mediaeval Maritime Asia overlapped with the “old” networks of proto- and early historical Monsoon Asia, thereby creating a historical continuum. This continuum may extend from the Sanskrit Cosmopolis and the Pali Cosmopolis in Sri Lanka and Mainland Southeast Asia to the Persianate and Islamicate worlds across the Indian Ocean, Maritime Southeast Asia, and Central Asia. The Islamicate circuits overlapped with, and sometimes replaced, the Indic circuits of cultural exchange—witness the circulation of Tamil, Arabic, and Malay materials across South India, Sri Lanka, and the Malay-Indonesian world explored by Ricci (2011), or the movement of an Arabo-Malay diaspora across the Indian Ocean over the past 500 years studied by Ho (2006), or again the spread of Islam at the hands of Muslim traders across Monsoon Asia/Indian Ocean world discussed by Prange in his *Monsoon Islam* (2018).²⁹

²⁹ Note that Prange uses the denominator “maritime Asia” multiple times in his book, along with the expression “Monsoon Asia”.

In conclusion, a reframing and reorientation of the parameters of the current scholarly debate into the direction of a (truly) “connected” and “borderless” history of Asia through the metaphor of Maritime Asia has the potential to bear an influence on current global imaginaries—witness the impact of such concepts as “Silk Roads” and “Eurasia”—as well as on issues of identity and heritage construction across the world’s most densely populated region. It may be apt at this point to quote Hann’s (2016) opening and concluding remarks in his thought-provoking article on the idea of Eurasia:

[...] to embrace Eurasia in the maximally inclusive sense corrects a long-term bias in the discipline [i.e. Anthropology] and at the same time gives it a fresh critical edge on the contemporary world. (2016, p. 2)

I therefore argue for an inclusive conception of Eurasia in a double sense, socially and territorially. My expansive territorial usage would become universal if the establishment of a Eurasian political-economic unity were to be the prelude to a world society. If this remains utterly utopian, those fortunate enough to be able to make their living as scholars are nonetheless free to uphold such a concept, to explore its historical roots and probe its potential in the present. We are free to theorize and investigate empirically a Eurasian mental space—analogueous to the way Europe is currently specified in the charters and treaties of the European Union. (2016, p. 8)

I would make an analogous point about Maritime Asia. It is perhaps significant in this context to mention a governmental undertaking recently inaugurated by India, i.e., Project Mausam (2014–2019), described as “an exciting, multi-disciplinary project that rekindles long-lost ties across nations of the Indian Ocean ‘world’ and forges new avenues of cooperation and exchange”.³⁰ Its goals are, according to India’s Ministry of Culture, to transcend the present-day ethnic and national boundaries, revive the lost linkages countries along the Indian Ocean shared with each other for millennia, as well as to constitute “a platform to connect discrete Cultural and Natural World Heritage sites across the Indian Ocean ‘world’ by providing a cross-cultural, transnational narrative”.³¹ By imagining Maritime Asia as a geographical arena with a shared history of human migration,

³⁰ <http://ignca.gov.in/project-mausam-3/project-mausam> (accessed 29 June 2019).

³¹ <https://www.iaspreparationonline.com/project-mausam> (accessed 29 June 2019).

long-distance trade, linguistic contact and dispersal, and cultural transfer, we may be able to narrate highly fluid translocal dynamics and, perhaps, long-term continuities, which transcend metageography and geopolitical divisions that artificially fragment what were in origin shared cultural processes.

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